August 25, 2021

Mr. Scott F. Thompson
Alternate Designated Agency Ethics Official
Office of the General Counsel
Department of Defense
Washington, DC 20301

Dear Mr. Thompson:

The purpose of this letter is to describe the steps that I will take to avoid any actual or apparent conflict of interest in the event that I am confirmed for the position of Deputy Under Secretary of Defense for Personnel and Readiness, Department of Defense. It is my responsibility to understand and comply with commitments outlined in this agreement.

SECTION 1 – GENERAL COMMITMENTS

As required by the criminal conflicts of interest law at 18 U.S.C. § 208(a), I will not participate personally and substantially in any particular matter in which I know that I have a financial interest directly and predictably affected by the matter, or in which I know that a person whose interests are imputed to me has a financial interest directly and predictably affected by the particular matter, unless I first obtain a written waiver, pursuant to 18 U.S.C. § 208(b)(1), or qualify for a regulatory exemption, pursuant to 18 U.S.C. § 208(b)(2). I understand that the interests of the following persons are imputed to me:

- Any spouse or minor child of mine;
- Any general partner of a partnership in which I am a limited or general partner;
- Any organization in which I serve as an officer, director, trustee, general partner, or employee; and
- Any person or organization with which I am negotiating or have an arrangement concerning prospective employment.

In the event that an actual or potential conflict of interest arises during my appointment, I will consult with an agency ethics official and take the measures necessary to resolve the conflict, such as recusal from the particular matter or divestiture of an asset.

If I have a managed account or otherwise use the services of an investment professional during my appointment, I will ensure that the account manager or investment professional obtains my prior approval on a case-by-case basis for the purchase of any assets other than cash, cash equivalents, investment funds that qualify for the regulatory exemption for diversified mutual funds and unit investment trusts at 5 C.F.R. § 2640.201(a), obligations of the United States, or municipal bonds.

I will receive a live ethics briefing from a member of the ethics office after my confirmation but not later than seven days after my appointment pursuant to the ethics program regulation at 5 C.F.R. § 2638.305. Within 90 days of my confirmation, I will submit my Certification of Ethics Agreement Compliance which documents my compliance with this ethics agreement.

I understand that as an appointee I will be required to sign the Ethics Pledge (Exec. Order No. 13989) and that I will be bound by it. Among other obligations, I will be required to recuse from particular matters involving specific parties involving my former employer or former clients for a period of two years after I am appointed, with the exception of Federal, states and local governments.

I will not modify this ethics agreement without your approval and the approval of the U.S. Office of Government Ethics pursuant to the ethics agreement requirements contained in the financial disclosure regulation at 5 C.F.R. § 2634.803(a)(4).

SECTION 2 – RESIGNATIONS

Upon confirmation, I will resign from my position with Stone Ridge School of the Sacred Heart. I terminated my employment with the National Military Family Association, Inc. in February 2021. Pursuant to the impartiality regulation at 5 C.F.R. § 2635.502, for a period of one year after my resignation or termination from each of these entities, I will not participate personally and substantially in any particular matter involving specific parties in which I know that entity is a party or represents a party, unless I am first authorized to participate, pursuant to at 5 C.F.R. § 2635.502(d).

SECTION 3 – RETAINED POSITIONS

I am the sole owner of my consulting LLC, which does business as A20 Strategies, LLC. Upon confirmation, my consulting LLC will cease engaging in any business. All amounts owed to A20 Strategies, LLC by any of the clients will be fixed before I assume the duties of the position of Deputy Under Secretary, and I will not participate personally and substantially in any particular matter that to my knowledge has a direct and predictable effect on the ability or willingness of any of these clients to pay these amounts. During my appointment to the position of Deputy Under Secretary, the LLC will remain dormant and will not advertise. I will not perform any services for the LLC, except that I will comply with any requirements involving legal filings, taxes and fees that are necessary to maintain the LLC while it is in an inactive status. As Deputy Under Secretary, I will not participate personally and substantially in any particular matter that to my knowledge has a direct and predictable effect on the financial interests of A20 Strategies, LLC. In addition, pursuant to the impartiality regulation at 5 C.F.R. § 2635.502, I will not participate personally and substantially in any particular matter involving specific parties in which I know a former client of mine is a party or represents a party for a period of one year after I last provided service to that client, unless I am first authorized to participate, pursuant to 5 C.F.R. § 2635.502(d).

SECTION 4 – SPOUSE EMPLOYMENT

My spouse works as a consultant. For as long as my spouse continues to provide these services, I will not participate personally and substantially in any particular matter that to my knowledge has a direct and predictable effect on my spouse's compensation or contracts, unless I first obtain a written waiver, pursuant 18 U.S.C § 208(b)(1). Pursuant to the impartiality regulation at 5 C.F.R. § 2635.502, I also will not participate personally and substantially in any particular matter involving specific parties in which I know a client of my spouse is a party or represents a party, unless I am first authorized to participate, pursuant to 5 C.F.R. § 2635.502(d).

SECTION 5 – EXEMPTIONS

If I rely on a *de minimis* exemption under 5 C.F.R. § 2640.202 with regard to any of my financial interests in securities, I will monitor the value of those interests. If the aggregate value of interests affected by a particular matter increases and exceeds the *de minimis* threshold, I will not participate personally and substantially in the particular matter that to my knowledge has a direct and predictable effect on the interests, unless I first obtain a written waiver pursuant to 18 U.S.C. § 208(b)(1).

SECTION 6 – PUBLIC POSTING

I have been advised that this ethics agreement and the Certification of Ethics Agreement Compliance will be posted publicly, consistent with the public information law at 5 U.S.C. § 552, on the website of the U.S. Office of Government Ethics with ethics agreements of other Presidential nominees who file public financial disclosure reports.

Sincerely,

Ashish S. Vazirani